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Suitable Sites for City-owned Grocery Stores

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Final Project

Affordability in New York City

The cost of groceries has become a concern for everyone in the United States. In 2024, Donald Trump won votes for the presidency from people who believed he would lower the cost of groceries. In 2025, Zohran Mamdani won the election for mayor of New York City with a similar message. As Trump's policies work to increase eligibility requirements for SNAP and thus cut benefits for thousands of families, Mamdani campaigned on a promise of affordability. One of Mamdani's campaign promises was to "create a network of city-owned grocery stores focused on keeping prices low, not making a profit" (*Platform* | Zohran for NYC, n.d.). This has inspired the guiding question for this project...

Affordability in New York City

Where should the Mamdani administration locate city-owned grocery stores in NYC?

While the average profit margin for a grocery store in the US is 1.4%, costs could be decreased by eliminating rent payments and property taxes (David, 2025; *Platform | Zohran for NYC*, n.d.).

Determining Suitable Sites

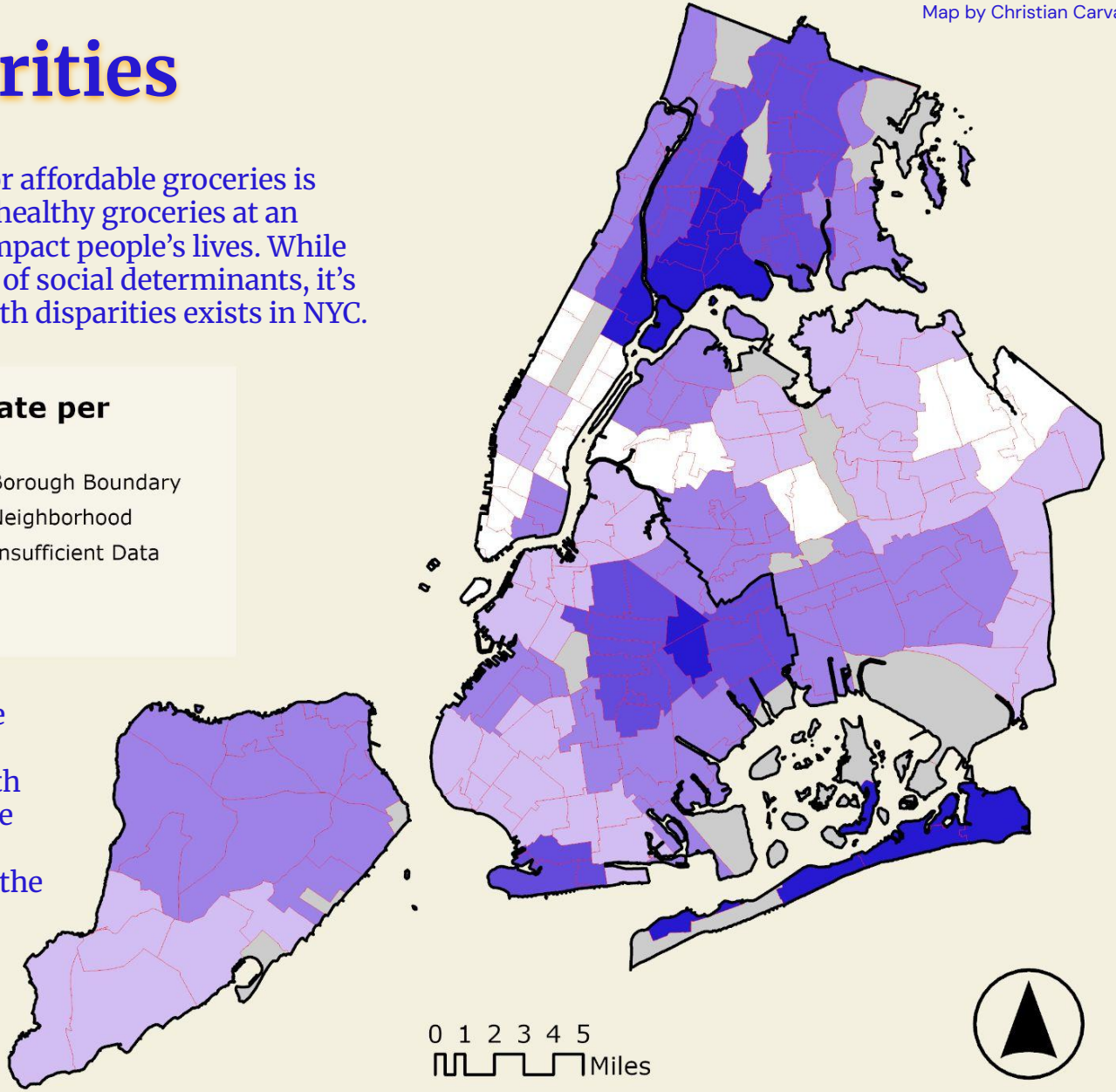
This research project ties the issue of **food insecurity** to the issue of **affordability** in order to ground policy around city-owned grocery stores to the daily lives of the most vulnerable New Yorkers. Questions to guide this research include:

- What criteria indicate a high need for more affordable groceries in a neighborhood?
- Where are existing grocery stores, FRESH zoning, and FRESH supermarkets located?
- What neighborhoods does a multi-criteria decision analysis (MCDA) show as benefiting the most from city-owned grocery stores?
- What city-owned land or vacant lots have the potential to be turned into supermarkets in the resulting areas?

Sources: NYC Department of City Planning (DCP) - Borough Boundaries, 2025, & Neighborhood Tabulations Areas (NTA), 2025.

Health Disparities

At the core of everyone's need for affordable groceries is their health and diet. Fresh and healthy groceries at an affordable price can positively impact people's lives. While health is influenced by a variety of social determinants, it's clear that a spatial divide in health disparities exists in NYC.



A higher age-adjusted death rate indicates a higher premature mortality. Essentially, poor health outcomes increase death in these areas as opposed to old age. The map shows this in East Harlem, the South Bronx, Brownsville in Brooklyn, and most of the Rockaways in Queens.

Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; NYC Health Department, 2022.

Food Insecurity

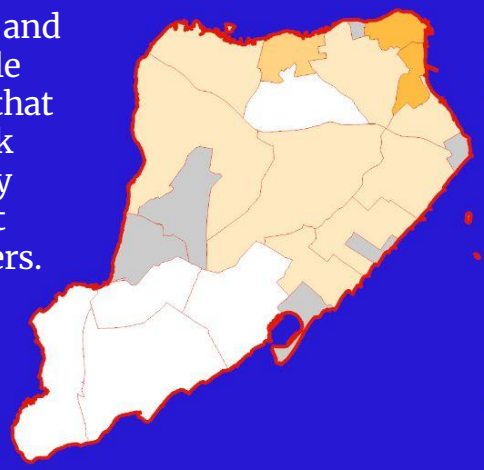
Estimated Percentage of Population that is Food Insecure (by Neighborhood), 2025

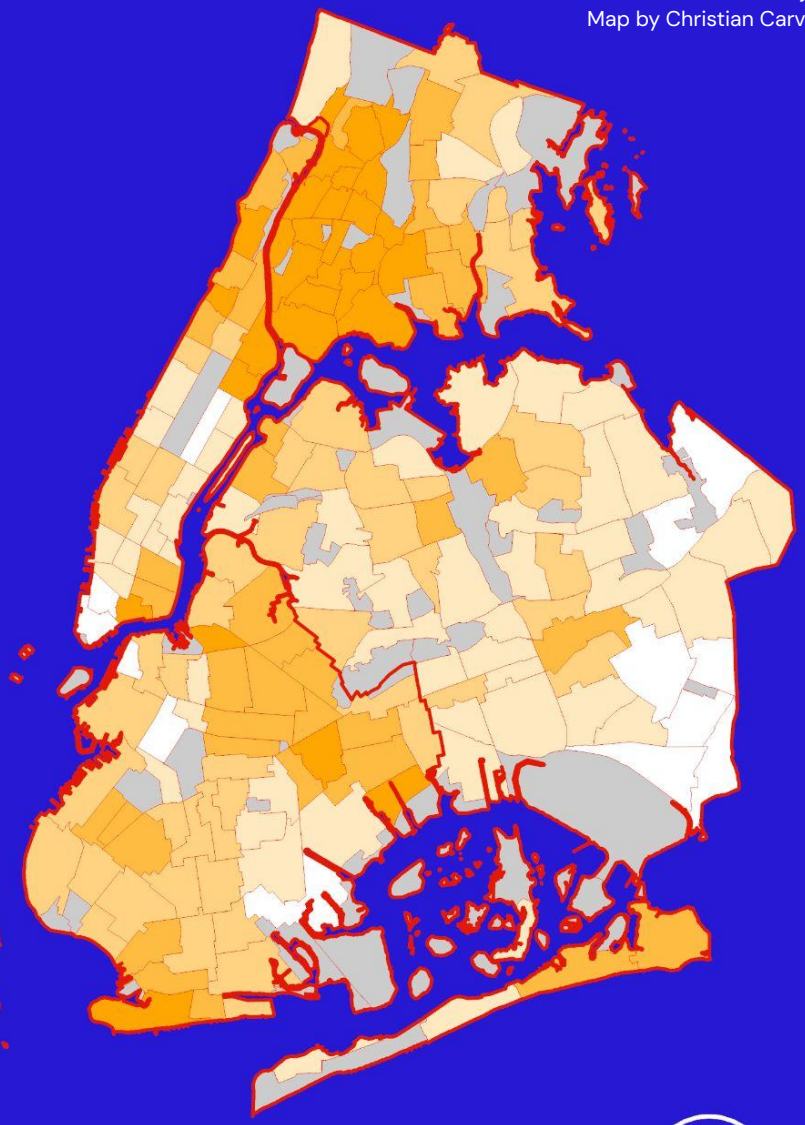
- 5.8 - 11
- 12 - 15
- 16 - 19
- 20 - 24
- 25 - 35

- Borough Boundary
- Neighborhood
- Insufficient Data

Food insecurity is a "household-level economic and social condition of limited or uncertain access to adequate food" (Healthy People 2030: Food Insecurity, n.d.). The same report makes it clear that the risk for food insecurity goes up when an individual has less or no money to buy food.

The ability to buy fresh produce and healthy groceries at an affordable price is a public health concern that should encourage the city to pick locations for city-owned grocery stores that will have the greatest impact on vulnerable New Yorkers.

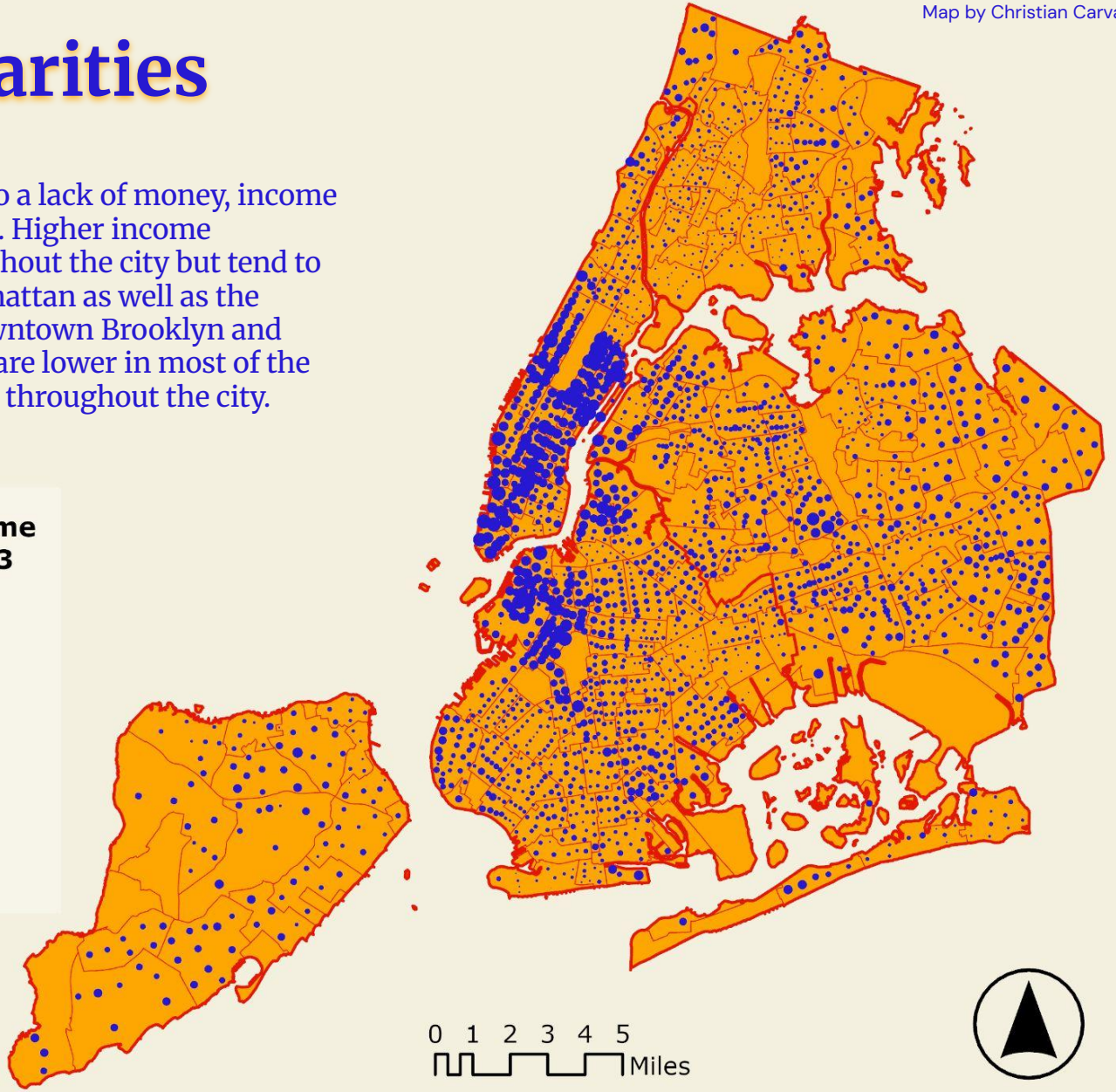




Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; NYC Mayor's Office of Food Policy, 2025.

Income Disparities

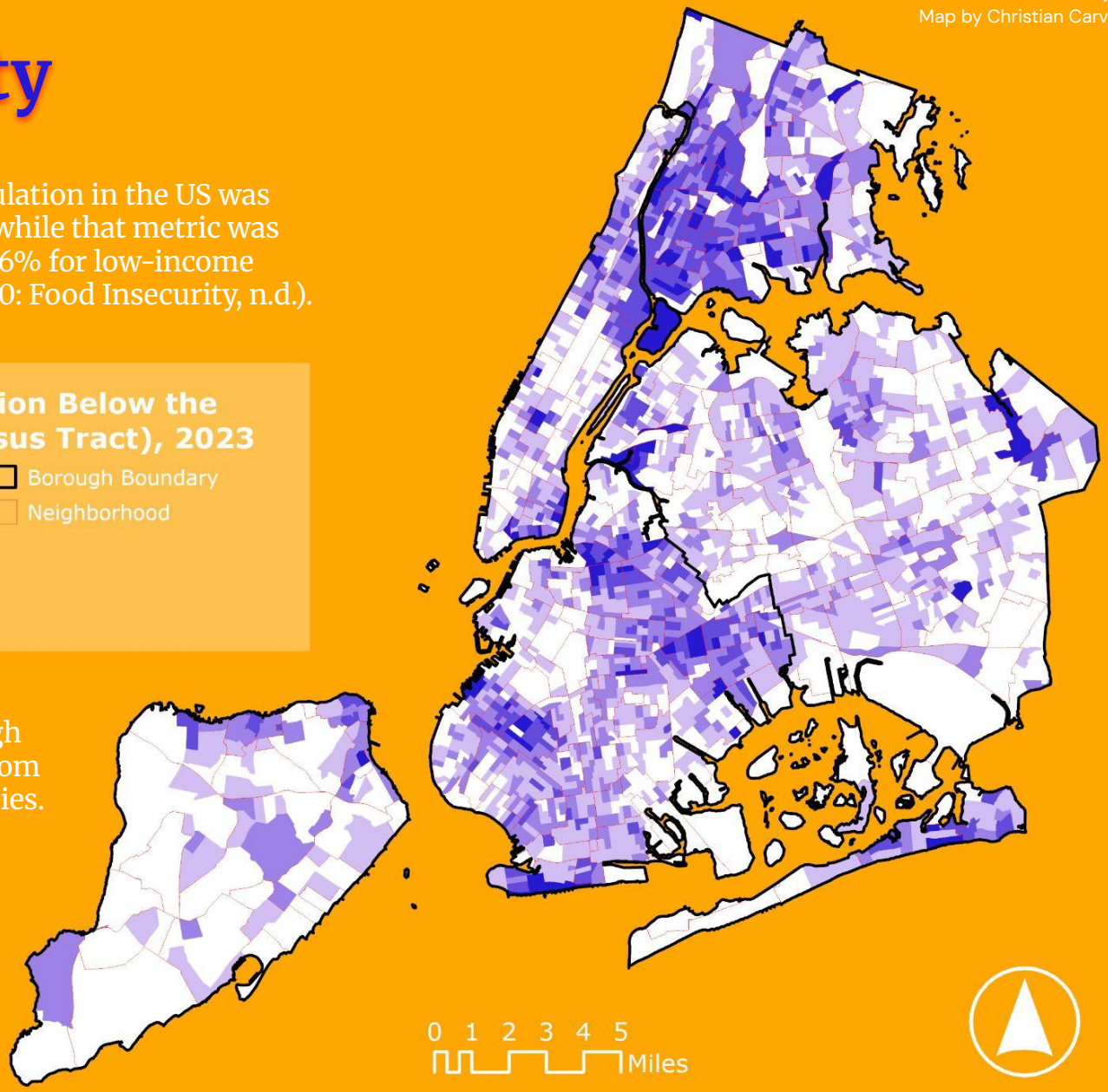
Because food insecurity is tied to a lack of money, income distribution must be considered. Higher income households can be found throughout the city but tend to cluster in the lower half of Manhattan as well as the Brooklyn neighborhoods of Downtown Brooklyn and Williamsburg. Median incomes are lower in most of the Bronx and other neighborhoods throughout the city.



Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 5-Year Estimates, 2023.

Urban Poverty

In 2020, about 10.5% of the population in the US was considered to be food insecure, while that metric was almost three times higher at 28.6% for low-income households (Healthy People 2030: Food Insecurity, n.d.).

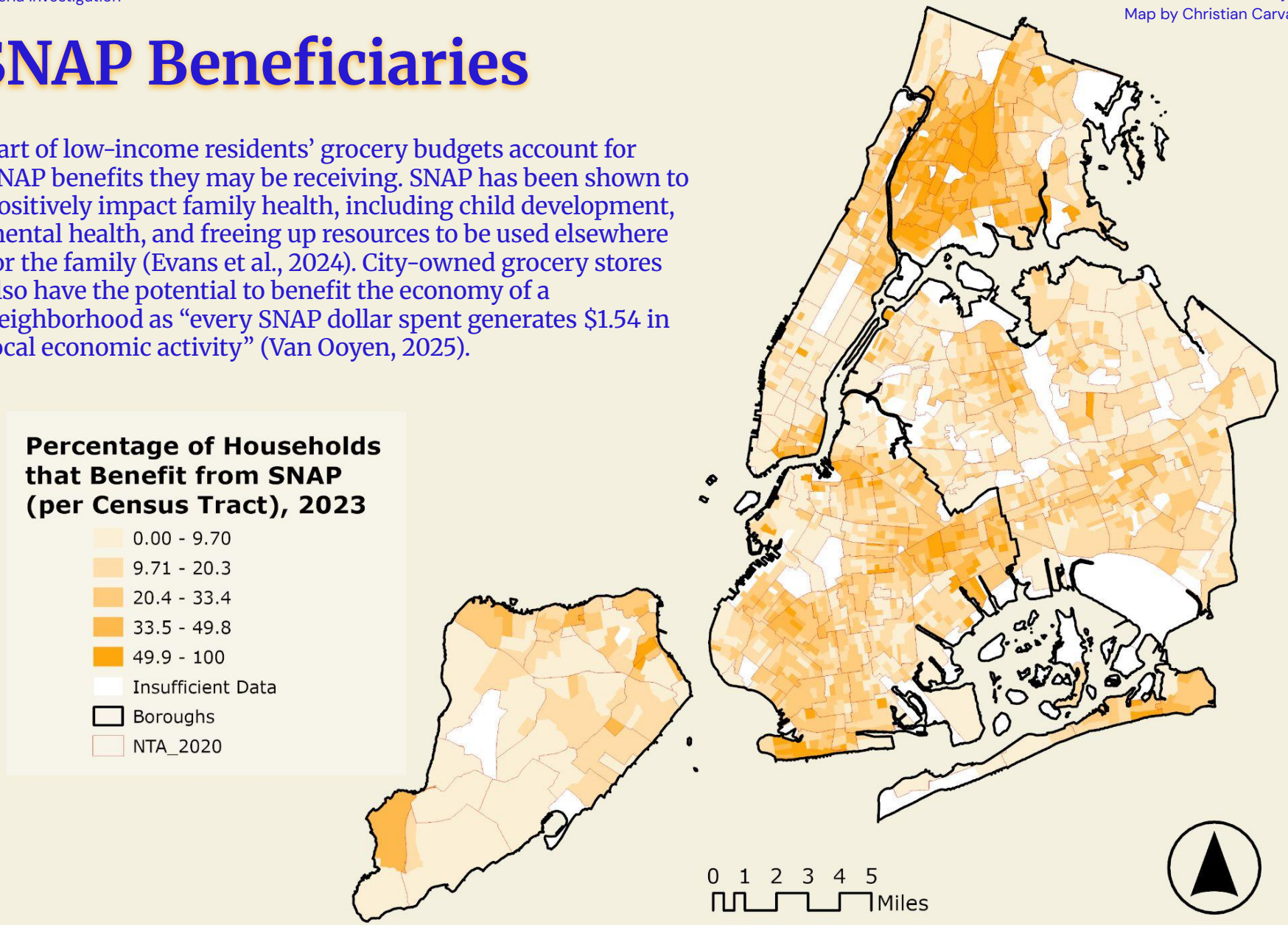


Areas with low-incomes and high poverty would greatly benefit from increased affordability in groceries.

Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 5-Year Estimates, 2023.

SNAP Beneficiaries

Part of low-income residents' grocery budgets account for SNAP benefits they may be receiving. SNAP has been shown to positively impact family health, including child development, mental health, and freeing up resources to be used elsewhere for the family (Evans et al., 2024). City-owned grocery stores also have the potential to benefit the economy of a neighborhood as "every SNAP dollar spent generates $1.54 in local economic activity" (Van Ooyen, 2025).



Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 5-Year Estimates, 2023.

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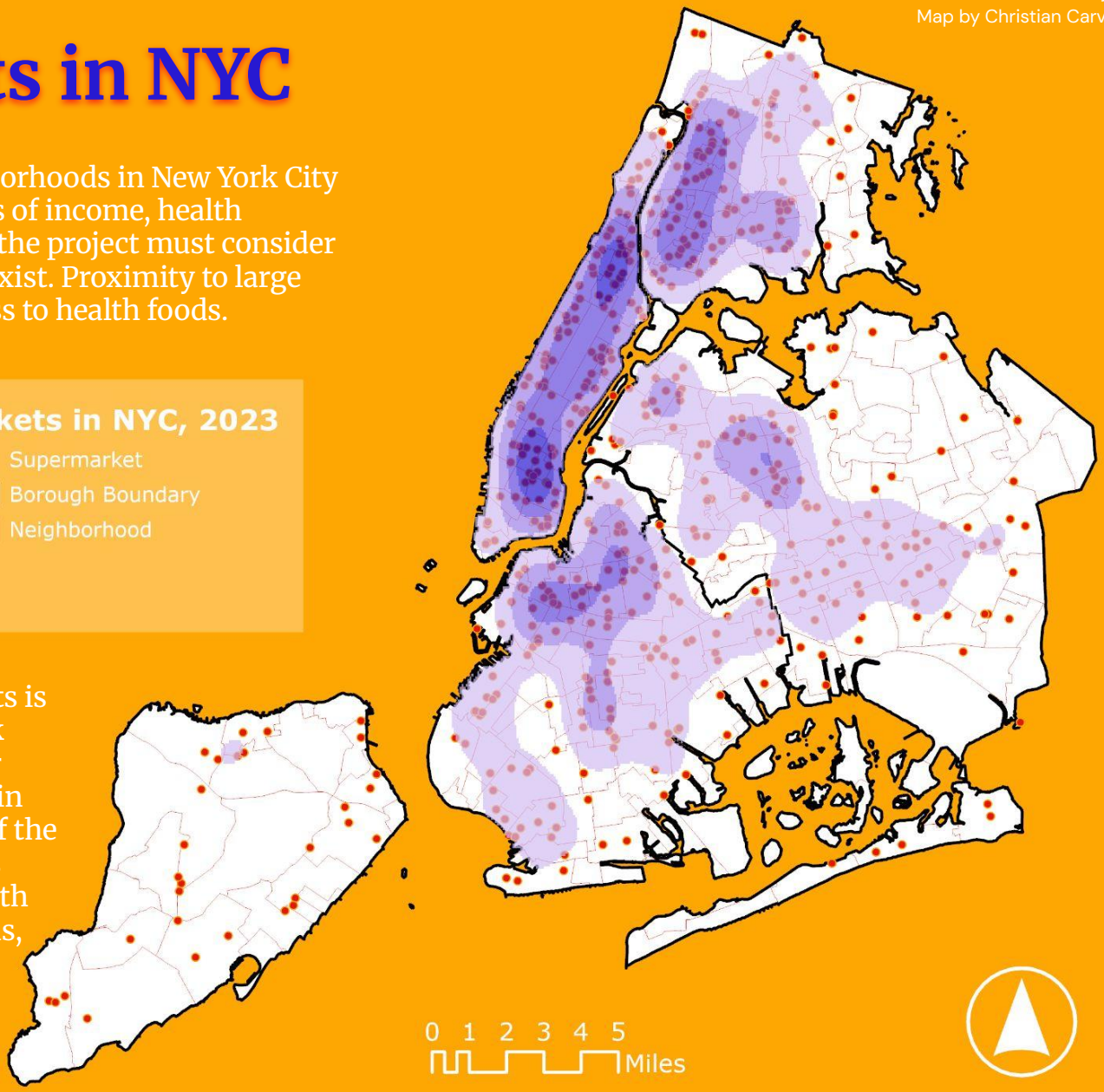
Map by Christian Carvajal

Supermarkets in NYC

As it becomes clear what neighborhoods in New York City are the most vulnerable in terms of income, health disparities, and food insecurity, the project must consider where supermarkets currently exist. Proximity to large supermarkets can indicate access to health foods.

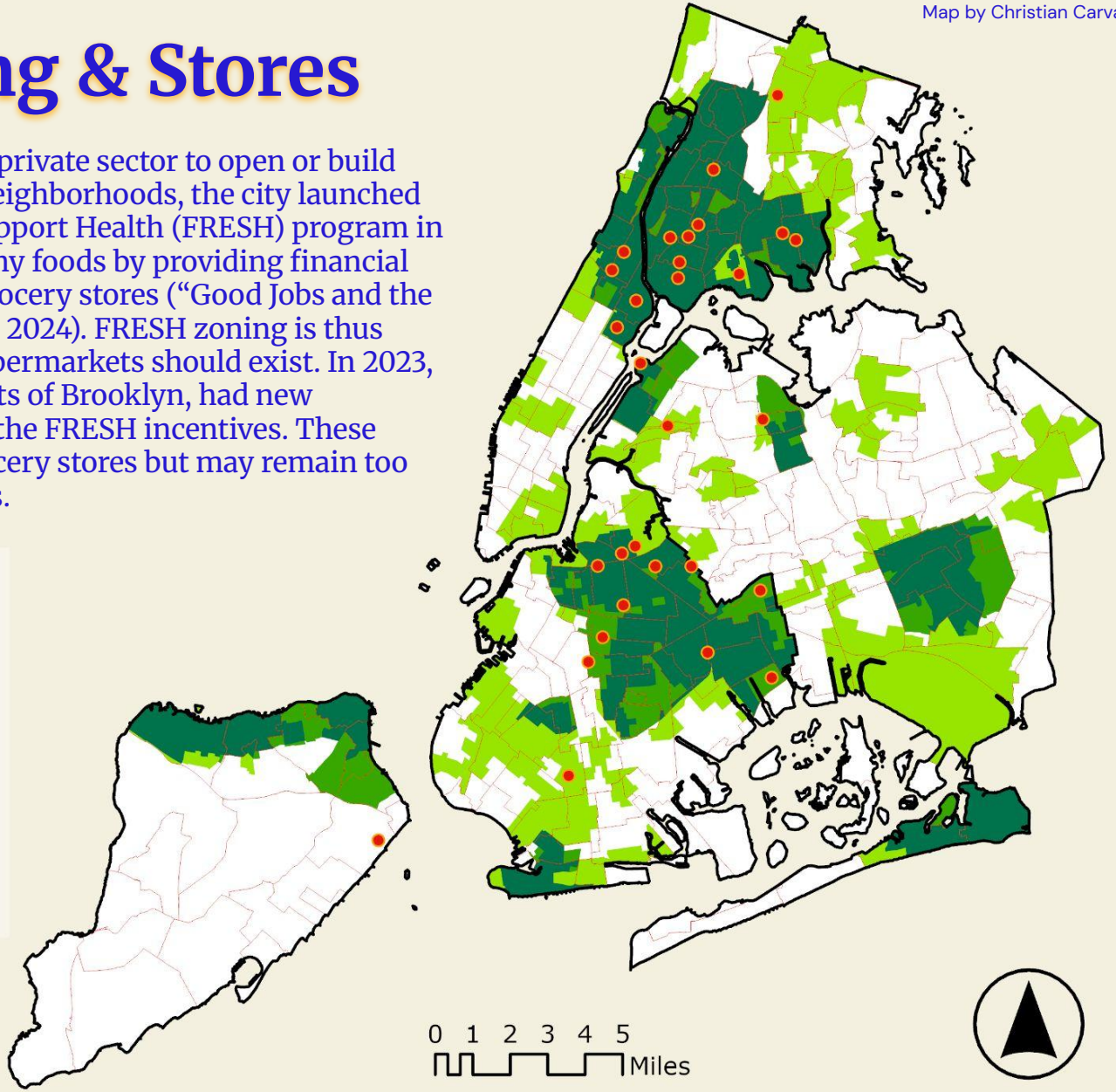
A higher density of supermarkets is noticeable in the same New York neighborhoods that have higher median incomes as well as a bit in the vulnerable neighborhoods of the Bronx and East Harlem. Perhaps health outcomes may change with new grocery stores in those areas, but proximity does not indicate affordability.



Sources: NYC DCP, MapPLUTO, 2025; Ruth Milkman, New York City's Retail Grocery Industry, 2021.

FRESH Zoning & Stores

In an attempt to incentivize the private sector to open or build supermarkets in underserved neighborhoods, the city launched the Food Retail Expansion to Support Health (FRESH) program in 2009 to promote access to healthy foods by providing financial and zoning incentives to new grocery stores ("Good Jobs and the New York City FRESH Program," 2024). FRESH zoning is thus where the city believes more supermarkets should exist. In 2023, East Harlem, the Bronx, and parts of Brooklyn, had new supermarkets benefitting from the FRESH incentives. These stores impact the density of grocery stores but may remain too expensive for some New Yorkers.



Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; NYC Economic Development Corporation, 2023.

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Suitable Neighborhoods for City-owned Grocery Stores

The Mamdani campaign proposed a pilot program in which one city-owned grocery store would be opened in each of the five boroughs. The most suitable neighborhoods are indicated on the map. The analysis considered multiple criteria and weighted it as follows:

- Premature Mortality - 13%
- Food Insecurity - 12%
- Median Household Income - 20%
- Poverty - 13%
- SNAP - 15%
- Supermarket Proximity - 7%
- FRESH Zoning - 12%
- FRESH Stores Proximity - 8%

Sources: NYC DCP, 2025; Criteria investigated in previous maps within this report.

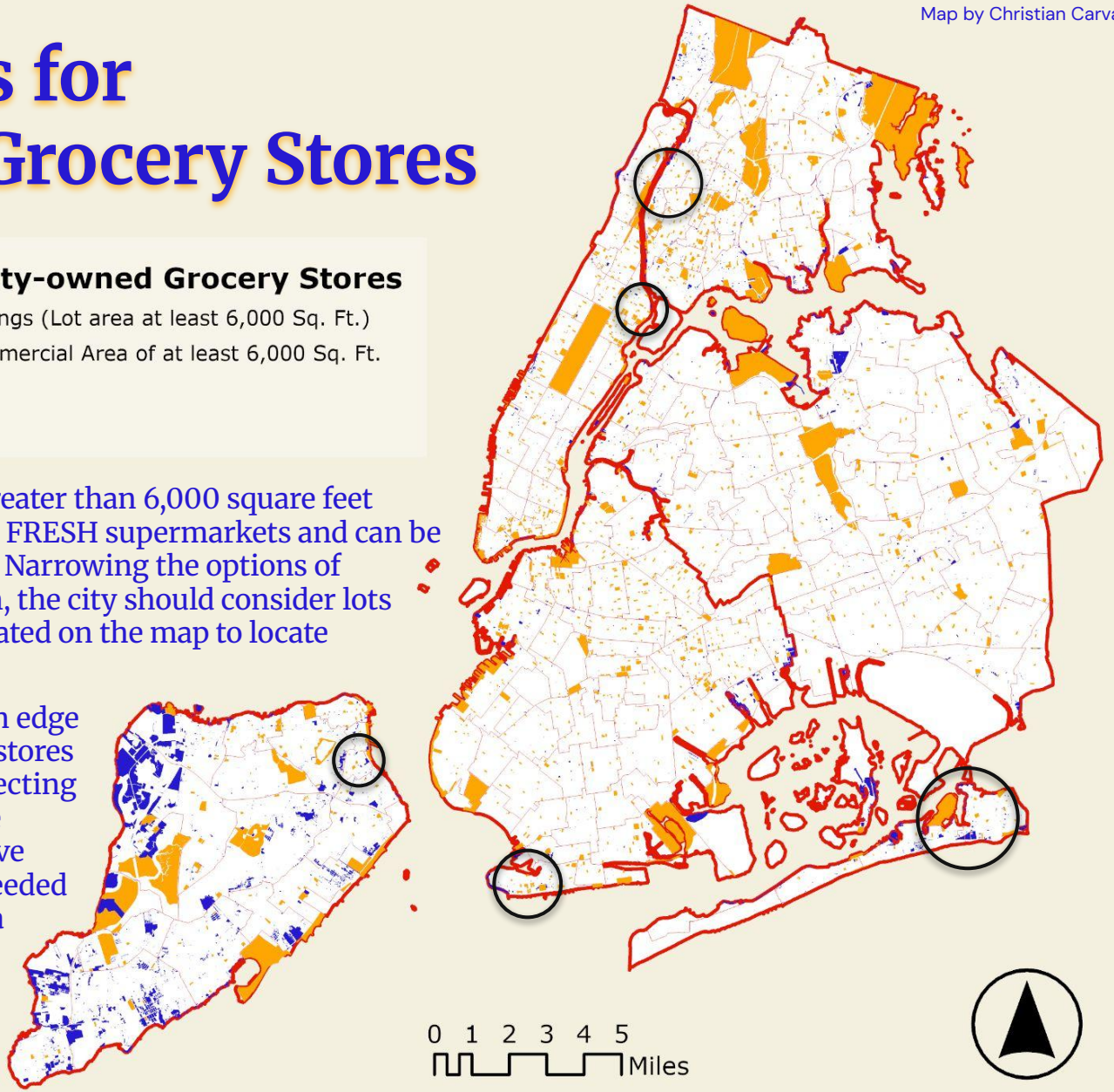
Suitable Sites for City-owned Grocery Stores

Potential Lots for City-owned Grocery Stores

- Vacant Lots with No Buildings (Lot area at least 6,000 Sq. Ft.)
- City-owned Lots with Commercial Area of at least 6,000 Sq. Ft.
- Borough Boundary
- Neighborhood

Lots and commercial space of greater than 6,000 square feet meet the city's requirements for FRESH supermarkets and can be used to determine suitable sites. Narrowing the options of suitable sites to one per borough, the city should consider lots within the neighborhoods indicated on the map to locate city-owned grocery stores.

On Coney Island and the western edge of the Bronx, the lack of FRESH stores is the determining factor for selecting each area over the other suitable neighborhoods in their respective boroughs. Further research is needed into each lot and its viability as a grocery store.



Sources: NYC DCP, MapPLUTO, 2025.

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